GEO CHECKLIST

GET YOUR BRAND CITED BY AI

Generative Engine Optimisation — 6-step action checklist

01
AUDIT YOUR AI VISIBILITY
4 tasks

02
WRITE IN CITABLE UNITS
5 tasks

03
SCHEMA MARKUP
4 tasks

04
ORIGINAL RESEARCH
4 tasks

05
AI-NATIVE DISTRIBUTION
4 tasks

06
MONITOR & REFRESH MONTHLY
4 tasks

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Work through each step in order — they build on each other.

For each task, mark your status: TODO → DOING → DONE

Use the Notes field to log URLs, dates, or owners.

Revisit monthly. GEO is ongoing, not a one-time fix.

Want us to run this for your brand?
Request your free AI citation audit.

Free AI Visibility Audit

© 2026 Mad Hat Communications | madhatcomm.in | Not for redistribution

STEP 01

AUDIT YOUR AI VISIBILITY

Find the gaps before you fix them

01

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Query multiple AI engines**	ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity & Gemini — use incognito/fresh sessions	*20–30 niche questions per engine*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Log citation sources**	Note every brand, domain, or publication that gets cited — and why	*Build a simple spreadsheet*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Identify 5 unclaimed Q opportunities**	Questions in your niche where no clear answer source dominates	*These become your content targets*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Benchmark your own brand mentions**	How often does your brand appear? In what context?	*Score: 0 = invisible, 5+ = visible*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE

▪ **Pro tip: Phrase questions the way a real buyer would — 'best [tool] for [use case]', not brand names.**

STEP 02

WRITE IN CITABLE UNITS

Structure content so AI can extract & quote it

02

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Define the key term in first 200 words**	AI models extract definitions from early in the document	*E.g. 'GEO is the practice of...' in paragraph 1*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Use strict H1 → H2 → H3 hierarchy**	Semantic structure helps AI parse section intent	*One H1 per page, no skipping levels*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Add a comparison table per pillar page**	Tables are highly citable -AI loves structured data	*Columns: Tool / Use case / Cost / Best for*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Add FAQ block with 5–8 Q&A; pairs**	FAQ format maps directly to conversational AI responses	*Use question as H3, answer in 2–3 sentences*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Write 40–60 word summary per section**	Concise summaries are the most-cited content unit	*Place directly under each H2*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE

▪ **Pro tip: Each section should be able to stand alone as a quotable answer — imagine AI lifting just that block.**

STEP 03

SCHEMA MARKUP

Speak the language machines parse

03

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Add Article JSON-LD on every post**	Includes author, date published, headline, publisher	*Validate at search.google.com/test/rich-results*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Add FAQPage JSON-LD on every FAQ section**	Maps your Q&A; pairs to structured data	*One FAQ schema per page max*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Add HowTo schema on process pages**	Step-by-step content performs well in AI summaries	*Include tools, duration, steps*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Validate all schema monthly**	Broken schema silently drops your AI surface area	*Set a calendar reminder*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE

- **Pro tip: Don't just validate — preview how it renders. Rich snippet appearance in SERPs = AI confidence signal.**

STEP 04

ORIGINAL RESEARCH

Become the primary source AI cites

04

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Run 2 data studies per quarter**	Survey data, aggregated client data, industry polls -any original stat	*Even 50-person surveys count*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Pitch findings to 5+ publications**	Citations from authoritative domains boost AI visibility dramatically	*Target: industry newsletters, niche blogs, trade press*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Create a 'State of [Niche] Report'**	Annual reports become evergreen citation sources	*Name it something memorable and repeatable*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE
☐	**Build a public data asset or calculator**	Interactive tools generate organic links and AI mentions	*E.g. 'ROI calculator', 'Benchmark report'*	▪ TODO ▪ DOING ▪ DONE

- **Pro tip: One widely-cited stat outperforms 10 generic articles. Make your data quotable — lead with the number.**

STEP 05

AI-NATIVE DISTRIBUTION

Publish where AI models read

05

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Publish on Perplexity Pages**	Content indexed directly into Perplexity's knowledge layer	*Repurpose your top pillar content*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Publish LinkedIn Articles (not just posts)**	Long-form LinkedIn is crawled and cited — posts are not	*500+ word articles with headers*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Build a Substack presence**	Substack content is increasingly cited in AI responses	*Weekly or bi-weekly is sufficient*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Submit to relevant wikis / community docs**	Wikipedia-adjacent sources carry heavy citation weight	*Contribute, don't spam*	TODO / DOING / DONE

- **Pro tip: Don't spread thin — pick 2 channels and publish consistently. Frequency beats breadth.**

STEP 06

MONITOR & REFRESH MONTHLY

GEO is a loop, not a launch

06

	TASK	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW / EXAMPLE	STATUS
☐	**Set up AthenaHQ or Profound**	Track how often your brand appears in AI answers	*Free tiers exist ~~set~~ up before you need it*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Re-query your 20~~-30~~ benchmark questions monthly**	Manual audit catches what tools miss	*10 minutes/month — log in your spreadsheet*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Refresh top 10 pages every quarter**	AI models favour recently-updated, accurate content	*Update stats, add new FAQ pairs, refresh examples*	TODO / DOING / DONE
☐	**Monitor competitor citations**	Who is getting cited instead of you ~~and~~ why?	*Close the gap on their citation triggers*	TODO / DOING / DONE

NOTES / URLS / OWNER

_____

_____

- **Pro tip: Set a recurring 'GEO Day' — one focused session per month beats constant half-measures.**

YOUR GEO SCORE

Count your DONE items across all 6 steps

0–6 NOT STARTED
Start with Step 01 — audit your visibility today.

7–12 EARLY STAGE
Good start. Prioritise Steps 02 & 03 for fast wins.

13–18 IN PROGRESS
Solid foundation. Push original research to amplify.

19–24 STRONG
Your content is AI-ready. Focus on distribution now.

25–28 GEO-OPTIMISED
You're ahead of 95% of brands. Keep the loop running.

STEP	TITLE	TASKS	DONE
01	AUDIT YOUR AI VISIBILITY	4	
02	WRITE IN CITABLE UNITS	5	
03	SCHEMA MARKUP	4	
04	ORIGINAL RESEARCH	4	
05	AI-NATIVE DISTRIBUTION	4	
06	MONITOR & REFRESH MONTHLY	4	

TOTAL: /28

Get Your Free AI Visibility Audit

Free AI Visibility Audit

© 2026 Mad Hat Communications I madhatcomm.in I Not for redistribution